Isaac and Rose

By Jared Boticelli

INTRODUCTION

VOICE OF MINISTER: *Dearly beloved, we gather here today to honor the memory of Isaac Keller, a beloved soul who touched our lives in countless ways . . . His sister, Rose has prepared a few words in his memory.*

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ROSE adjusts a microphone stand before tapping it and saying . . .

ROSE: **(Pg 25-31)** Is this thing on? *(beat)* That was a joke. Funny, huh? Ok, well, maybe not. I thought, you know, make some jokes, warm my audience up a little bit. Maybe I could be like a stand-up Helen Keller. Well, I can talk though. Sort of. *(speaks very slowly and with much exaggeration)* Can you understand me? You're nodding, so I guess that's a yes. Let me tell you the biggest joke, though. The fact that I'm the one up here. But they asked that I talk about him and I . . . *(beat)* The deaf older sister pays tribute to her genius little brother. That was another joke. Ha. ha. ha. They would call that poetic irony, right? *(stares out into the audience)*

They asked me to tell you about him, so . . . He started playing when he was three. Really. Would climb right up onto the stool and would stare at the keys like he was studying them, and he would make up little songs. I was eight, almost nine then, and these things *(motions to her ears, indicating her hearing aids)* still worked a little. I could make out some of the songs. The things he was able to do with the piano by the time he was five, six, seven. Our parents both played and they were letting him listen to Wagner, Tchaikovsky, Bartok. By this time, I heard less and watched more. How about a nine-year-old who can play? Ha. His hands were too small to play those big octaves, so he would *(motions crossing her hands over each other, as if playing. Closes her eyes)* Rachmaninoff's 3rd Concerto. . . that was the last piece I can remember being able to hear him play. *(shakes off the memory)*

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Jokes. Yes, we, well, I, I was talking about jokes. Maybe God likes to do experiments sometimes and see how ***good*** he can make someone. Isaac -- this perfect little person. Sitting at that big black piano, he looked like that big piano could just swallow him up whole. . . . Or the math he did in his head. Foreign languages. They tested him when he was, I don't know, seven or so, his IQ . . . *(her voice fades off and she gazes out into the audience, perhaps as if she sees him)* How do you compete with that? To have that kind of talent and then to be that . . . ***good***. A good person. Humble. Kind.

Let's say something about ***my*** personality. Bitter. Angry. Impatient. Then think of the opposite and that's Isaac. I think I was in 5th grade when my teacher told me, "You are so smart, Rose. So smart. But you are so angry." Yeah, *(clears her throat, recomposes herself)* jealousy is a bitter, toxic disease. A poisonous weed that grows without end. I am it's victim. Powerless to it. A disease worse than the fever that screwed up my ears when I was a baby or that shut down my *(gestures towards her right kidney)* Well, we will get to that. *(pause)* To really talk about Isaac I think I have to talk about me. *(a small, mirthless laugh and then she speaks quickly, almost garbling her words)* Self-consumed. Self-involved. Self-centered. Self. Self. Self.

(a memory comes to mind) We were fighting; well, not fighting, because he didn't do that. I was being a horrible 15-year-old, throwing a fit . . . he was 10, I'd had some crap happen at school and I was angry, like always, and he told me *(beat)* I understand you. And I told him. I told him you don't. I. . . God, I pushed him into the pool. I did. *(gestures as if holding Isaac under water)* I pushed him under the water. He was so small. And I, I held him there. I didn't let him up. *(to Isaac)* "Do you, Isaac? Do you "understand" me? This is how it is. Can you hear me?!" *(gestures releasing him -- lets out a long, slow breath)* And I let him up. He was okay. Shaken up. But okay. My parents, always the loving, supportive mother and father, comforting us both. And he said, "I love you, Rose." No. You don't. You shouldn't. *(pause as another memory comes)*

He drew a picture of us sitting on a piano bench on the beach, and you can see the

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ocean in the background. He's playing and I'm looking out towards the waves. We look happy. People are rarely happy. Maybe God makes more mistakes than we want to admit. *(another steady, long breath before refocusing on the audience)*

High fevers. Crap ears. Inside parts that don't work well. My parents should have asked for a refund. Or at least an upgrade. I guess that's why they got Isaac. Good for them. They deserved him. I mean that. For every award that Isaac won, I had a new doctor or a new issue that needed attention. And, then the big one hit. The kidney's main job is to remove the toxins out of the blood and mine were just really tired of doing that. *(holds her side and pauses)* They put you on a list. And they tell you to stay strong and be patient. Which is great advice while your internal organs betray you and your body rots. Crappy body. Rarest blood type. Poetic irony.

You spend a lot of time feeling sorry for yourself, and you're angry and sick, and sometimes you yell at your little brother when he lies down next to you, and you drum your fists over his back. *(pause)* And sometimes you let him curl up next to you and feel his heartbeat. *(gasps, suddenly and unexpectedly.)* And you pray to God to be forgiven and to be a better person. And you watch your little brother play the piano and you wish, you wish that you could hear him.

Our parents take us to the beach. I try to be decent, I do. But I just keep thinking that it's like a movie about the angry, dying deaf girl who gets taken to the seaside by her loving parents and genius little brother and they all bond and she becomes Pollyanna and . . . I'm no Pollyanna. *(pause)* Isaac, a teenager now, and I were walking along the beach and he told me *(she silently mouths, You're my hero.)* And I told him *(speaks with anguish, as if she can barely get the words out)*, "No, Isaac. I'm ***not***. I'm not anybody's hero. I am so angry. You have everything. Everything!" And I ran as fast as a sick girl can, leaving him standing there. He didn't run after me -- He just stood there, looking out over the sand towards the water. Life sucks compared to the movies. People are rarely truly happy. *(pauses and then smiles, almost garishly and cracks a joke)* Two

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gnomes walk into a bar. *(pause)* This isn't really a time for jokes.

Soon after the time at the beach, my number came up. *Ding ding ding!* The sun is coming up and it's just my Dad and me driving to the hospital. And he says some things but he's driving, so I can't see his lips. His eyes water and he looks older than before. And I think, all of this because of me. And it seems so unfair. They suit me up and after a while, I'm floating into a place with dark, black pools of liquid, dreaming that my ears are perfect again and I'm listening to Isaac play. Then my body goes heavy and I give way to the darkest sleep. *(pauses and closes her eyes, placing her hands at her side, near her kidney. Her eyes open)* You wake through a dark fog. My parents are there. Both are crying. And it's the loudest sobbing, although I can hear nothing but the huge silence. My side aches. My mouth is dry as sand, but I can barely drink. I choke. Mom and Dad are at my bedside. Their faces are broken puzzles. I ask for Isaac. My brother. My Isaac. They are both crying now, and it's like a boiling river inside of me, because I feel him there. I cannot survive this. I thrash so hard that the IV rips from my arm, and I'm on the floor and they are holding me. I'm 3 again with a fever so high that I'm burning up, a field of fire, a desert of flames, and I wonder if a river of tears could carry us away, out to the ocean and will we find Isaac there, whole, unharmed. I sleep. I hope to not awaken. *(pauses to recover from her tears)*

(softly) Isaac knew that I would have said no, would have fought it physically if I'd known. My parents didn't even try to talk him out of it and they never blamed me. I don't really know how that's even possible. He had a reaction to the anesthesia and he . . . um, he went to sleep. He was 15 years old. And this is what's left *(she gestures down at her side)* This is the part of him that he gave so that I could stay alive. I wonder sometimes -- What was Isaac's last thought as he slipped into that sleep? Fear? Anger? Regret? I cannot understand that generosity of spirit. Maybe I am incapable of it. Isaac gave me his kidney -- I did nothing to deserve this. *(beat)* A great movie of the week. *(a short, mirthless laugh)* Oh God . . . *(has to pause)*

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So, thank you all for coming here today, for him. But he wasn't much for taking credit. He got nervous before he performed. He was shy, humble. He was the strongest and most beautiful person I have ever known and I am **trying** to be a better person, a ***good*** person, to . . . *(pause)* honor him.

If I hadn't been so angry, so unwilling to be happy, maybe I would have [been able to] to explain to him how much I loved him. *(looks heavenward)* Thank you, Isaac. I love you forever and ever. I'm sorry and I'm remembering what you told me. You knew so much for a little kid. You told me, even though something is tough, it doesn't mean it's impossible. So, I'm trying. It's hard but I'm trying.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier
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